Taranaki Secondary Schools Rogaining Championships 2013

Nick Collins



In late 2004, a few of us had the idea that a local schools rogaine may attract a few competitors, and in March of 2005, we ran our first TSSSA (Taranaki Secondary Schools Sports Association, http://www.tsssa.org.nz/tsssa/) rogaine attracting nearly 100 students. We were jubilant in our success. In this our 9th year the event has swelled to 737 competitors battling it out in 3 age grades and 3 gender categories over the 3 hour event. The success of the event is a surprise to us and I thought in putting pen to paper I might give some of you an idea on how to get started copying us. It's just a matter of being organised and persistent.

The event at this scale of course requires considerable organisational skill and we are fortunate in Taranaki to have a first class team. The busses arrive at the car park between 5pm and 5:30 and with the briefing scheduled for 5:40 we have to be sharp. An organiser boards each bus as it arrives, checking off teams and ensuring that wrist tags are strapped on before the students can get off the bus. From there it is relatively easy to get them into the box for the briefing which they all ignore and then out for the 6pm start.

The finish also has potential for chaos, 737 sausages to cook and give out, ditto 737 cans of coke. Hundreds of parents clogging up the finish chute, so that the competitors can't find it. Nervous counting to find out if everyone's in taking into account those that have retired and are being brought back in the lag car or are at one of the two Search and Rescue station.

So here are some of the main issues that we think makes this all possible:

1. Get it on the local secondary schools calendar. It would be impossible if it were not an official event.
2. Use the same area every year. You don't need to find fresh navigational challenges.
3. Pick an area that is very rich in tracks. A mountain bike park is ideal.
4. Think about the map boundaries. Ours is bordered by a state highway on one side, a river on the other and impenetrable bush on a short third boundary. We don't think anyone can wander off the map by mistake.
5. Keep the controls on tracks. Don't be tempted to add a few hard ones for the guns. They'll still win. Stumbling onto controls allows teams to relocate.
6. Include some time in the dark. We run from 6pm till 9pm giving about an hour in the dark. Kids just love getting their torches out.
7. Get your search and rescue procedures sorted and publicised. This year we had the local S&R team at our event. We had a written plan, great communications and 2 remote manned sites. When we left the event at 10pm, S&R were in fact busy trying to find 2 of their team who had become geographically embarrassed.
8. Keep it cheap. We charge $8 per person, but have significant sponsorship from NZRA, Fowler Homes and Downer Construction.
9. Do it every year. Popularity grows and eventually it's a stampede.

Well what are you waiting for? We now have the largest secondary school event in Taranaki, dwarfing other TSSSA events such as athletics and rugby. Students come to participate not just because of the athletic and mental challenge, but also for the social aspects and the good fun. For the organisers at Orienteering Taranaki, there have been tangible benefits. Navsports are becoming cool and attendance at our sprint series is up, membership is growing and our Facebook site is well "liked". Give it a go.

For some pictures and results see http://www.tsssa.org.nz/tsssa/rogaine/ and for the competition map see http://rogaine.org.nz/main/NewsItems/TSSSARogaineMap_2013.pdf

Nick Collins, 17th March 2013